THE KANE ACADEMY · FREE GUIDE FOR PARENTS

The Full Season Blueprint

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for parents of basketball players

> What to say, and what to stop saying, at the four moments that shape your child's season: tryouts, the car ride home, playing time, and the voice in their head after a mistake.

By Coach Dennis Kane

440 Wins · CIF Champion · 1,000+ Parent Conversations · 12 Pros · 71 College Players
And A Development Plan For You And Your Kid

Keep it handy all season.

START HERE

Your child's season isn't decided on the court. It's shaped by what surrounds it.

After 440 wins and 1,000+ parent conversations, I can tell you where seasons are won and lost. Not in the gym. In the car, at dinner, in the doorway on the way out, and in the stands.

Every parent I've coached wanted their child to succeed. That has never been the problem. The damage comes from good intentions delivered at the worst possible moment: a pep talk that lands as pressure, a question that asks for a verdict, a silence that reads as disappointment.

WHAT'S INSIDE

1. **Pre-season & tryouts.** Ten mistakes that cost confidence, the three windows that decide it, and what to say when the list doesn't have his name on it.
2. **The car ride home.** The first five minutes, and what to say when they do want to talk.
3. **Playing time.** The three things that decide minutes, and who should ask the coach.
4. **Mental toughness.** The four checks that teach a kid to talk to himself instead of listen to himself.

Read it slowly. Most parents find one habit in here that changes the whole season. Talent determines what your child *can* do. What surrounds him determines what he's willing to try. That's the part you control.

CHAPTER ONE

PRE-SEASON & TRYOUTS

10 mistakes that cost confidence

None of these come from a bad parent. All ten come from a parent trying to help at a moment when helping isn't the job.

MISTAKE 1

The parking-lot pep talk

“Today's the day. Go prove yourself.” You mean it as fuel. He hears that the next two hours decide who he is.

> SAY THIS:
> “You've already put in the work. Go compete and have fun.”

MISTAKE 2

Scouting the gym out loud

Counting the other kids, sizing up who's tall, naming who made it last year. You're teaching him to measure himself against the room instead of against the rep in front of him.

> DO THIS:
> Say nothing about anyone else in the building.

MISTAKE 3

Coaching from the bleachers

Tryouts are an evaluation, and a coach watching your child glance at you after every possession is watching a kid who isn't free.

> DO THIS:
> Sit where he can't find you. Clap for the whole floor.

MISTAKE 4

Asking “How did you do?”

It asks for a verdict he isn't qualified to give and hasn't been told yet. He'll guess, and he'll usually guess low.

> SAY THIS:
> “What did you compete hardest at today?”

MISTAKE 5

Approaching the coach mid-tryout

Anything you say during an evaluation window reads as lobbying, and it attaches your name to his.

> DO THIS:
> Wait. If there's a conversation to have, it happens after the list, in private.

MISTAKE 6

Comparing his tryout to another kid's

“Jaden looked slow out there.” It feels like reassurance. It teaches him that his standing depends on someone else's bad day.

> DO THIS:
> Compare him only to his own tape from last season.

MISTAKE 7

Treating the list as a verdict on the kid

A roster is a coach's read of a fit, on one week, for one team. Your reaction is what turns it into a statement about his worth.

> DO THIS:
> Separate the outcome from the identity, out loud, in the first minute.

MISTAKE 8

Blaming the coach when it doesn't go his way

It feels loyal. What it teaches is that outcomes are decided by other people, which is the foundation of every excuse he'll make for the next ten years.

> SAY THIS:
> “What do you think he was looking for that we can go build?”

MISTAKE 9

Fixing it for him

The email, the phone call, the conversation you have on his behalf. The adversity was the curriculum. Removing it removes the lesson.

> DO THIS:
> If a question needs asking, he asks it. You drive.

MISTAKE 10

Going quiet

The silent car, the shortened dinner, the warmth that doesn't come back until the next good day. Kids read withdrawal faster than criticism.

> DO THIS:
> Same voice, same warmth, same night. Especially that night.

CHAPTER ONE · TRYOUTS

The three windows that decide it

Removing pressure isn't enough on its own. You have to put something steady in its place. Here is what your job is in each window, and just as importantly, what it isn't.

WINDOW ONE

The week before

Your job: lower the stakes without lowering the standard.

- Ask once, early: “What's one thing you want to show them?” Then leave it alone.
- No new training program, no cram sessions. Nothing built in one week shows up in that gym.
- Protect sleep and food harder than you protect gym time.
- Don't rehearse outcomes out loud: not making it, making it, which team. He's already running those.
- Mute the three accounts that make you anxious about where he should be by now.

WINDOW TWO

Tryout day

Your job: be boring, warm, and unreadable.

- Arrive early. Rushed is a mood he carries onto the floor.
- In the doorway: “Go compete. I love watching you play.” That's the whole speech.
- Sit where he can't easily find you, and away from the loudest parents in the gym.
- Clap for the floor. Not just for him, and never at a coach.
- Stay flat on mistakes. Your face after a turnover is the only scouting report he's reading.

WINDOW THREE

The first eight seconds after

Your job: say almost nothing, and mean it.

- Pause. Smile first, before any words.
- Then one of: “I loved watching you compete.” · “You worked hard out there.” · “How did it feel?”
- Then stop. If he wants to talk, he will. If he doesn't, that's information, not rejection.
- No technical feedback for 24 hours. Not one note, however gently you'd deliver it.

CHAPTER ONE · AFTER THE LIST

When the list doesn't have his name on it

This is the moment parents ask me about more than any other, and it's the one most of them handle backwards. Not out of carelessness, but because watching your child hurt makes you want to do something, and almost everything there is to do makes it worse.

THE FIRST HOUR: SAY THIS

“I'm sorry. That one hurts.”

“I'm proud of you for putting yourself out there.”

“Nothing about today changes anything between us.”

Then stop. Don't explain the decision, don't diagnose it, don't promise it'll be different next year. He isn't ready to hear any of it and none of it is the thing he needs in that hour.

THE FOUR THINGS NOT TO DO

Don't blame the coach. It feels like loyalty. What it teaches is that his outcomes belong to other people, and that's the seed of every excuse he'll make for the next decade.

Don't make the call. If there's a question worth asking, he asks it, a few days later, in private. You drive him there.

Don't go quiet. Withdrawal of warmth is read as a verdict. Same voice, same dinner, same night.

Don't immediately go shopping for another team. Rescuing him from the disappointment removes the only part of this with any value in it.

Then, after a week, and not before, there's one question worth having him ask the coach: *"What do I need to work on to be considered next time?"* Write the answer down. Work on that specific thing, and only that thing, for a defined stretch. Confidence doesn't come back because you told him he's good. It comes back because he got measurably better at the thing he was told he was missing.

CHAPTER TWO

THE CAR RIDE HOME

The drive home isn't your coaching moment.

Twenty years from now your child won't remember the score. They'll remember whether you were their biggest supporter or their harshest critic. The drive home is where that memory gets made.

COACH KANE'S CORE PRINCIPLE

“If they want to talk, listen. If they don't, let them process.”

THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

Before you leave the parking lot

Your job: set the tone for the whole night in one sentence.

- Your first words: “I love watching you play.” Nothing else.
- Don't bring up the game. They decide if and when to talk.
- If they're quiet, let them be quiet. Silence is not a problem to fix.
- Never criticize the coach, the referee, or a teammate in the car. Your child hears “not good enough.”

WHEN THEY DO WANT TO TALK

Listen first

Emotions are indicators, not dictators.

- Ask “How did you feel out there?” before anything about points.
- Ask the questions a coach asks: “Did we play hard? Did we do what we were told?”
- Let them name their own mistakes before you name any.
- Point out one effort play (a loose ball, a box-out, a sprint back) over any score.

WHAT TO SAY INSTEAD

~~“Why didn't you shoot?”~~

“I loved how hard you ran back.”

~~“That ref cost you the game.”~~

“What do you think you learned tonight?”

~~“We need to talk about your defense.”~~

“Want to grab something to eat?”

Praise that builds, when real basketball talk belongs, and the 24-hour rule for a concern about the coach are in **the Basketball Parent IQ System**.

CHAPTER THREE

PLAYING TIME

Three things decide minutes. Talent is third.

Every parent has asked it: “Why isn't my kid playing more?” In 44 years of coaching, the answer almost always came down to the same three things. Two of them are completely in your child's control.

COACH KANE'S CORE PRINCIPLE

“Playing time is earned, not given.”

NUMBER ONE

Doing what you're told

Coaches play the kids they trust to run the plan. That trust is built in practice, not in games.

> ASK AFTER GAMES:
> “Did we do what we were told?”

NUMBER TWO

Playing hard

Sprinting back, loose balls, box-outs, every possession, at both ends of the floor. Coaches notice it before anything else.

> PRAISE THIS:
> the effort plays, more than the points.

NUMBER THREE

Talent

It grows, but it takes years of focused, correct repetition. Practice wrong and you get better at wrong.

> **REMEMBER:**
> fifteen focused minutes beat two hours of messing around.

HOW TO TALK ABOUT MINUTES

Who should ask the coach

The conversation that earns playing time is between the player and the coach. Not the parent and the coach.

- Your child asks: “Coach, what do I need to improve to earn more minutes?”
- If a parent has to step in, use the 24-hour rule: wait a full day after you're upset, then ask for a conversation.
- Never before or after a game. Never by text in the heat of the moment.
- The word to use is **development**, not minutes. Ask what your child needs to develop, and the coach hears a partner instead of a complaint.

WHAT TO SAY INSTEAD

~~“The coach has favorites.”~~

“What did Coach say you need to work on?”

~~“I'm going to talk to the coach.”~~

“You ask Coach. I'll help you practice it.”

How to build the coach's trust at home, the practice plan that grows talent, and the exact script for a parent-coach meeting are in **the Basketball Parent IQ System**.

CHAPTER FOUR

MENTAL TOUGHNESS

Teach them to talk to themselves, not listen to themselves.

Your child's biggest opponent isn't on the other team. It's the voice in their head after a mistake. Listening hears “don't miss again.” Talking says “next play.” Here are the four checks that train that switch at home.

CHECK ONE

Self-talk

- ☐ My child has a 3-second reset after a mistake (a breath, a clap, one word) and uses it in games.
- ☐ “I can't” gets replaced with “How can I?” at home, not just at practice.

CHECK TWO

Breathing

- ☐ They know the box breath: in for 4, hold 4, out for 4, hold 4.
- ☐ Their free-throw routine starts with one breath, every time.

CHECK THREE

Process over outcome

- ☐ Our post-game questions are about effort and execution, not points.
- ☐ They can name the three things they control: effort, attitude, response.

CHECK FOUR

Pressure vs. pleasure

- ☐ I never let the pressure exceed the pleasure.
- ☐ I watch for the warning signs: dreading practice, pre-game anxiety, a lost spark, falling apart after mistakes. When I see one, I reduce pressure. I don't push harder.

WHAT TO SAY INSTEAD

~~"Don't miss this one."~~

"Breathe. Same routine."

~~"Why did you do that?"~~

"What's the next play?"

~~"You have to win today."~~

"Compete hard and have fun."

ONE LAST THING

Your child will forget most of the scores this season. He will not forget what your face looked like when he came off the floor, or what the car felt like on the way home.

That part is entirely yours. It's also the part that's still working on him twenty years from now.

YOUR NEXT STEP

This guide gives you the moments. The System gives you the season.

The four chapters above cover the moments parents ask me about most. The habits that shape your kid show up every single day: every car ride, every bad game, every hard talk with a coach.

As a head coach, my high school teams won 440 games. Twelve of my players went on to play pro. Seventy-one played in college. The same things that win games build good men. Mental toughness. Confidence. Resilience. They are built on the court and at home.

The Basketball Parent IQ System gives you my frameworks for building all three.

The Basketball Parent IQ System · $47

- The 14-day parent blueprint, 20 minutes a night
- Ten 60-second audio sessions, including how to talk to your kid's coach
- The car ride home framework
- A bonus chapter on AAU, recruiting and NIL

COACH DENNIS KANE